NAPA VALLEY TACO TOUR

El Taco Feliz

Napa Valley and Mexico have a long-entwined history that has blended their cultures together along the way. Street tacos, once serving mainly as an easy meal for workers, have become a go-to food option beloved by all. Today, taquerias are located all over the valley, whether brick-and-mortar restaurants or food trucks. Most specialize in classic "street tacos," plates of smothered tortillas that are typically prepared quickly, packed with flavor in an array of combinations and able to be eaten handily.

A proper street taco needs just five ingredients: tortilla, meat, sauce, cilantro and onion. The magic happens in high quality ingredients.

It all starts with the tortilla. Dough made of *masa harina de maíz* and water is pressed flatly and cooked to form the base of a taco dish. The best tortillas are handmade to order and warmed on a grill. Then the meat gets added.

Any taco spot worth its salt offers *pollo asado* (grilled chicken). *Carne* (steak) is also a staple protein, often coming in multiple options such as *asada* (grilled slices), *suadero* (braised), *cabeza* (beef cheeks) or *lengua* (beef tongue). Pork rounds out the big three, with *al pastor* (seasoned and topped with a pineapple slice), *carnitas* (braised) and *chorizo* (seasoned sausage), perhaps the most popular. More adventurous palates can go for *chicharrón* (pork rind), tripa (intestine) or buche (pork stomach). The proteins may be simply grilled or seasoned with a mix of guajillo, ancho and chipotle chiles, achiote, cumin, garlic, onion and oregano.

Azteca Market & Taqueria

789 Main St., St. Helena
2995 Jefferson St., Napa
aztecanapavalley.com

This Mexican grocery store in St. Helena is home to one of the valley's most popular taco counters (there's a second location in Napa). The hedonistic street-style taco lineup includes basics such as *pollo asado*, *carnitas* and *chorizo*, along with traditional *buche*, *lengua* and *suadero*.

El Rodeo

1850 Soscol Ave., Napa
(707) 415-9800

This truck specializes in fresh seafood offerings like shrimp or fish tacos alongside with *aguachile* and seafood cocktail[UNCLEAR]. Try the *tripa* for an authentic and adventurous street taco bite. The taco *gobernadora*, with shrimp, cheese and grilled onions, is a heartier choice.

El Sabor Serano

1017 Coombsville Road, Suite B, Napa
elsaborserano.com

El Sabor Serano is located on the east side of Napa heading to Coombsville, next to the Fairview Market and not far from the Napa Valley Exposition. It's best to sit down at this restaurant for your meal. The *suadero* stands out for its juicy and tender beef. You're going to want as much *salsa verde* as possible as it is made with fire-roasted tomatillos that add a smoky depth to the sauce.

El Taco Feliz

Lake Street, Calistoga

This taco truck is just past the intersection of Silverado Trail and Lake Street. The lines are long for a reason—it's among the best spots in the valley and the service is always friendly. Their *carnes* are tender, juicy and packed with flavor. The *cabeza* stands out for its generosity of seasonings and melt-in-your-mouth braised beef.

Sauces add flavors that bring spice and acidity to the taco, usually as *salsa roja*, *verde* or *aguacate*. *Roja is spicy and smoky, made with tomatillos and chiles. Verde* is mild and tangy, made with tomatillo, cilantro and lime juice. *Aguacate* is a creamy version of salsa *verde* with avocado. Some places specialize in habanero for ultimate spice, or macha for an oily crispness. The street taco's final garnish is cilantro for freshness and chopped raw onion for a bitter crunch.

There are also seafood tacos which typically come with *pico de gallo*, cabbage and chipotle aioli. Vegan and vegetarian selections can also be found. Be mindful of levels of spiciness and your tolerance to them—the radish or cucumber slices typically served on the side are there to help if you take one of those too-hot bites. Some taquerias include carrots or grilled onions on the side for a sweet counterpoint.

When pairing wine with tacos, look for something with freshness and bright acidity, which cuts through the richness of the proteins and seasonings. A lower alcohol wine allows the taco's flavors to shine and keeps spice in the background. Sparkling wines are also a great option. Rich white wines can stand up

WS063026_napaTaco_draft.indd 2 3/26/26 10:08 AM

La Condesa Taqueria

1745 Soscol Ave., Napa
lacondesataquerianapa.com

Open early, La Condesa offers breakfast tacos and *licuados* (smoothies) along with traditional street tacos. The chorizo stands out for its seasoning and spices and is served on a toasted tortilla that holds together nicely. There may not be a better way to start the day than at this taqueria.

La Luna Market & Taqueria

1153 Rutherford Road, Rutherford
lalunamarket.com

Right in front of the Rancho Caymus Inn, this market and taqueria provides one-stop shopping for a taco picnic. The *pastor* and *pollo adobado* tacos shine here, with excellent seasonings and juicy meat. Conveniently, picnic tables surround the exterior of the market.

La Taquiza Fish Tacos

2007 Redwood Road, Napa
lataquizafishtacos.com

In the Redwood Plaza, this brick-and-mortar taqueria is known for its fresh seafood options. Shrimp, fish and octopus come in various formats such as ceviche or seafood cocktail. The fish taco can be battered and fried or seasoned and grilled, then topped with *pico de gallo*, cabbage and chipotle crema. The octopus is a standout—grilled fresh, tender and meaty.

Mother's Tacos

3150 A Jefferson St., Napa
madebymothers.com

Napa's newest taco joint is a fast-casual restaurant located in the Grape Yard shopping center. The tortillas are made in-house and provide the perfect platform for the traditional *carne asada*, *suadero* or *pollo asado*. The mushroom taco outperforms for its melt-in-your-mouth sweetness. Mother's offers four sauces at the table; be sure to try the oil-based macha sauce for great acidity and crunch.

Ray Ray's Tacos

1304 Main St., St. Helena
rayrays.com

Ray Ray's offers convenience with its tacos to go. Choose from various kits designed so you can build your own tacos. A tray of 16 street tacos tray makes things even easier—all you have to do is pick the meat. The spiced carrot taco here should not be missed, either. There is also plenty of seating for dining in.

Tacos El Muchacho Alegre

751 Jackson St., Napa
tacoselmuchachoalegre.com

This truck is just off Soscol where there are plenty of parking spaces and picnic tables. The spiced shrimp taco here is filled to capacity, with fresh slaw, *pico de gallo* and creamy aoli. Traditional meats, like the *al pastor*, are also seasoned perfectly.

Tacos Garcia (Truck)

6792 Washington St., Yountville
(707) 980-4896

Yountville's only taco truck is on the corner of Washington Street and Champagne Drive, one block from picnic tables, bocce and volleyball courts. The tortillas are lightly toasted on the grill, making them a firm base for the fillings (which are ample). Tacos Garcia specializes in the tender *lengua*. Be sure to top any taco with the to-die-for red tomatillo sauce.

Ray Ray's

Mother's Tacos

Tacos Los Compadres

Claremont Way, Napa
(707) 339-2305

Open until midnight, Tacos Los Compadres is a great spot for late-night munchies. The *al pastor* is one of the best in the valley. A *trompo* is used to spin the layered meat around a flame, crisping it until ready to be sliced, after which it is topped with slices of grilled pineapple that rotate on the trompo, above the *carne*. A salad bar on the outside of the truck allows you to conveniently top your tacos with as much cilantro, onions and sauce as you'd like.

Tacos Michoacan

1800 Pueblo Ave., Napa
(707) 812-9963

One of the longest-running taquerias in Napa (since the 1990s) this outfit sports a brick-and-mortar along with two trucks. With house-made tortillas, traditional meats and three sauces, Michoacan offers the archetypal Mexican street food. Their *carnitas* are spot on, with an intensity of saltiness and fattiness. Don't overlook their carrot side either, as it adds just the right sweetness to finish.

Recommended Wines

HYDE Pinot Noir Napa Valley Larry Hyde 2022
KINSMAN Eades Chenin Blanc Diamond Mountain District Aberro 2024
LOS CUERNOS Chardonnay California NV
NEWFOUND Grenache Napa Valley Yount Mill Vineyard 2022
NOMADICA California Bubbly White NV
SCHRAMSBERG Brut Rosé Napa Valley Querencia 2021
SPHAERICS Chardonnay Napa Valley Carneros Overline 2023
UNTI Vermentino Dry Creek Valley 2024

to the complexity of the taco, while lightly tannic red wines compliment the seasonings without accentuating spice. If you love a big red wine though, go ahead and have it with your tacos. Don't forget about canned wines, an easily transportable option if you're having a picnic.

—Chris Cardoso

WS063026_napaTaco_draft.indd 3 3/26/26 10:08 AM